Rather a tenuous link I contemplated, as Rehan continued his debriefing. I let the conversation ebb and flow over me as I mulled over possible options. Lawepura was one of those 'black' villages on the Srinagar–Baramulla highway. There had been stray incidents of stone-throwing at Army convoys passing through, and once even one instance of grenade-throwing. So, the probability of terrorists having taken shelter there was high. It was already late afternoon. Dusk would be upon us soon, earlier than usual because of the dark clouds. Go in now on this third- and fourth-hand information, with a hint of rain to complicate matters? How trustworthy were these guys? I hadn't even known of their existence until a few days ago. Although I knew of the village, having driven past it a few times, I did not know its exact layout.

'Where exactly is this friend's house?' I asked.

'In Dar Mohalla, next to the masjid.' That wasn't of much use, since I knew neither the *mohalla* nor the masjid. I tried another track. 'So, what exactly did this friend see and what did she tell Jameel's aunt?'

Painstakingly, the story emerged. The aunt had gone to visit her ailing friend. She had sensed a palpable tension in the house. There had been furtive looks and whispered conversations. Finally, the patient herself had told her not to tarry and to go home quickly. As she was leaving, she had indeed come across a young man, not of the household. And the clinching evidence—this young man had not known Kashmiri! Well, the ball was certainly in my court. This is when Jameel stepped in. Signalling for a paper and pen he swiftly drew some bold lines. Placing his sketch on my ornate walnut-wood table, he motioned to me to listen. In a mixture of Hindi and Urdu, he explained:

'This is the village; this is the main road, the masjid, the target house. In case they try to get out, this is the route they

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